THE COLLAR

A short film screenplay

A minimalist story about absence, routine, and quiet grief.

FADE IN:

INT. KITCHEN - MORNING

Pale winter sun cuts across yellowing linoleum floor tiles. ARTHUR (72) stands by the counter in a worn wool cardigan. A kettle comes to a low simmer on the stove. He reaches into a cabinet, pulls out two ceramic mugs out of habit, then stops. He sets one mug back on the shelf and closes the cabinet door quietly. On the floor beside the refrigerator sits a ceramic water bowl, full to the brim. A dry red plastic food bowl rests next to it, wiped clean. Beside the bowl lies a small faded red collar with a tiny bell. The kettle WHISTLES softly. Arthur turns off the burner.

INT. LIVING ROOM - LATE AFTERNOON

An armchair faces a cold fireplace. On the velvet cushion, a shallow, curved depression remains in the fabric, lined with thin grey hairs. Arthur walks into the room carrying his tea. He steps around the rug, avoiding the patch of afternoon sun on the carpet where the warmth hits. He sits on the far edge of the sofa, looking at the empty armchair. The house is quiet enough to hear the ticking of a grandfather clock in the hallway.

INT. KITCHEN - EVENING

Outside, dusk settles into deep navy blue. Arthur stands at the back door. He unlocks the deadbolt and cracks the door open two inches, as he has done every night for fifteen years. Cold air drafts into the kitchen. He waits by the open door for several seconds, looking into the dark garden. Nothing moves in the yard. Arthur closes the door softly, turns the deadbolt, and switches off the kitchen light. He walks back into the dark room, leaving the small red collar resting untouched beside the wall.

THE END

FADE OUT.